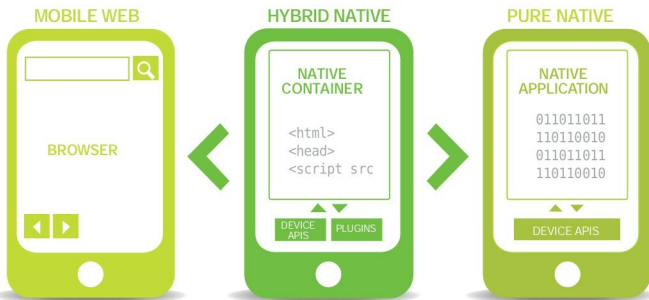


Build Your Own Mobile App in a Jiffy!

Smartphones have invaded our lives in a big way, and there is an all out effort to develop Web pages and Web apps that will enhance the user experience. In this article, the author discusses a three-pronged strategy for developing Web apps. Interested? Then read on.



In the era of smartphones, people are no longer using a computer to shop online, to book a train ticket or to get the headlines. Today websites are no longer viewed only on PCs. Users expect a website to look and function similarly on all the devices, and smartphones in particular. Till a couple of years back, Web development was considered a creative technical job, but now there is also the need for a well-planned strategy to cater to mobile users. Given the fragmentation of the mobile devices market and the dynamic user behaviour, there is no one stop solution that will please mobile device users.

Let's examine the strategic options available and check whether there are any open source technologies and tools to execute these options.

Mobile websites

How different is it to build websites for mobiles compared to building websites for PCs? Quite different, actually. Fitting Web components into mobile real-estate is altogether a different ball game. Responsive Web Design (RWD) expects reshaping and resizing of Web components for each and every design size. Realignment of the Web components according to device orientation—horizontal or vertical—is important. You need to be prepared for tiny mobile screens, not-so-tiny tabs and you can't stop the PC clients invading your site. A complex job indeed, but are there any tools and technologies available to address the requirements of handheld devices? The answer is yes, of course!

HTML5 with CSS3

HTML5 is cross-platform, which means you can use it for a tablet, a smartphone, a notebook or a smart TV. Officially, no browser supports HTML5 completely, but sooner or later, there will be support for at least all the popular tags.

The *Media Queries* feature of CSS3 allows you to target CSS rules based on, say, screen size, device-orientation or display-density. This means you can use CSS Media Queries to tweak CSS for an iPad, printer or to create a responsive site.

Twitter Bootstrap

Twitter Bootstrap was initially developed by Twitter for its internal projects, but was later published as an open source framework. It is basically a CSS framework shipped with various Web components in a 'ready-to-use' condition. These components help those with little or no design knowledge to achieve responsive Web designing, gaining acceptance in the world of Web development.

The pros and cons of mobile websites

Mobile website development consumes less time and effort. The user need not install the app in the device, but just needs to browse. The contents are on the Web. Search engines can index these sites and show them up in the search results. For users who don't want to install yet another app on their device, this is the best way forward. On the downside, mobile